FULL SEO AUDIT REPORT

merrittmason.com

Prepared by Claude SEO

28/100

SEO Health Score

October 26, 2026 Full Audit

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1. Executive Summary

This report presents a comprehensive SEO audit of **merrittmason.com** for a **Personal portfolio / individual professional** site, generated on October 26, 2026. Findings combine technical, content, schema, performance, visual, and search-readiness evidence as available.

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SEO HEALTH SCORE

Critical Issues Found:

1. **Info:** AI crawlers (GPTBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot) receive HTTP 403 from Vercel host-level rule
2. **Info:** Client-rendered SPA: raw HTML is an empty shell
3. **Info:** Soft 404: every path returns 200 with identical index.html
4. **Info:** Title 'About Me'; no meta description, canonical, Open Graph, or JSON-LD
5. **Info:** 2.1 MB PNG hero at 256 px; 9.8 MB PNG publicly served; LCP est. 3-4.5 s mobile

Quick Wins:

1. Disable Vercel Firewall AI-bot block
2. Set metadataBase to www host; add canonical, OG, twitter metadata
3. Paste Person/WebSite/ProfilePage JSON-LD into layout.tsx
4. Add app/robots.ts and app/sitemap.ts
5. Rewrite title and first paragraph as an entity statement (name, role, Charlotte NC)

2. Audit Categories

2.1 Technical SEO

Score: 28/100

What Works

- HTTPS + HSTS, single-hop 308 redirects
- viewport, theme-color, lang=en
- 1.9 KB shell from Vercel edge

Findings

Content client-rendered only Critical

Raw HTML 1948 bytes, empty #root, no body text

Recommendation: Server-render in Next.js rebuild

Soft 404 on every path Critical

/nonexistent-xyz returns 200 with same ETag as /

Recommendation: not-found.tsx; redirects() for old SPA routes

AI crawlers blocked (403) Critical

GPTBot/ClaudeBot/PerplexityBot UAs get 403; Googlebot/bingbot 200; robots.txt is 404 so host-level rule

Recommendation: Vercel Firewall: disable AI Bots managed rule

Weak title, no description High

<title>About Me</title>, no meta description

Recommendation: Metadata API: name + role + city title, description, OG, twitter

No canonical / OG High

Absent from HTML

Recommendation: alternates.canonical, openGraph with 1200x630 image

metadataBase host mismatch High

layout.tsx uses apex; live apex 308 -> www

Recommendation: metadataBase https://www.merrittmason.com

robots.txt 404 High

NOT_FOUND

Recommendation: src/app/robots.ts

No sitemap High

/sitemap.xml 404

Recommendation: src/app/sitemap.ts

Missing security headers Medium

Only HSTS; ACAO * on HTML

Recommendation: headers() in next.config.ts: nosniff, Referrer-Policy, X-Frame-Options, Permissions-Policy

No llms.txt Low

404

Recommendation: Optional public/llms.txt

2.2 Content Quality

Score: 34/100

What Works

- Real assets: GitHub repos, resume PDF, LinkedIn
- content/profile.md holds strong unpublished material (Coretek 360, AVERASE, NIST 800-88)

Findings

Thin content High

Home ~190 words; /contact ~15; /testimonials ~4

Recommendation: Bio, experience, education, 100-150 words per project

Current work missing High

Copy says 'student'; Coretek 360, AVERASE absent

Recommendation: Lead with current role and products

Weak E-E-A-T High

No dates, employers, schools, byline, schema

Recommendation: Dated experience/education; Person schema with sameAs

Vague copy Medium

'ability to develop my skills showcased in my portfolio'

Recommendation: One concrete quotable fact per sentence

/testimonials soft 404 with fake scaffolding Medium

200 with nav text only

Recommendation: Remove or redirect until real, permissioned quotes exist

Status wording conflict Medium

profile.md: degrees end 05/2026 + 'seeking internship' vs Product Engineer TBD start; certs lack issuers

Recommendation: Settle before publishing

No freshness signals Low

Date fallback 2026-01-01

Recommendation: Updated <month year>; dateModified

2.3 On-Page SEO

Score: 22/100

What Works

- lang=en, viewport, favicon on all routes
- Rendered DOM has resume, GitHub, LinkedIn, mailto links

Findings

Generic title on every route High

'About Me' everywhere

Recommendation: Merritt Mason | Software Developer and Product Engineer, Charlotte NC

No meta description High

None on any route

Recommendation: Per findings/content.md

Heading hierarchy Medium

Two H1s; 'My Experience' H2 is a skills list

Recommendation: One H1 name+role; H2 Experience/Projects/Skills/Education/Contact

No branded/local keywords Medium

'Charlotte', 'software developer' absent from text

Recommendation: Use in title, H1, intro

Contact page lacks details Medium

Link labels only; no email text

Recommendation: Show email, city, resume link

Minimal internal linking Low

Three nav links

Recommendation: Cross-link sections and footer

2.4 Schema / Structured Data

Score: 5/100

Findings

No structured data High

0 JSON-LD blocks live and in rebuild

Recommendation: Person + WebSite + ProfilePage @graph (findings/schema.md)

No Person sameAs High

GitHub/LinkedIn not declared

Recommendation: sameAs, jobTitle, alumniOf, address

worksFor unconfirmed Medium

Coretek 360 start date TBD

Recommendation: Add worksFor once confirmed

2.5 Performance (CWV)

Score: 62/100

What Works

- TTFB 93 ms, HTTP/2, brotli, edge cache HIT
- No third-party scripts, no web-font requests
- Inline theme script prevents flash

Findings

Oversized headshot PNG Critical

/headshot.PNG 2,119,525 B, 1254x1254, displayed 256 px

Recommendation: next/image sized, priority; AVIF/WebP

SPA shell delays LCP High

Content after JS; LCP est. 3-4.5 s mobile

Recommendation: Server components

Hero entrance animation Medium

framer-motion opacity 0->1, 0.2 s delay, 0.8 s duration on LCP element

Recommendation: Do not animate LCP element

JS bundle Medium

334 KB raw / 112 KB brotli single chunk

Recommendation: Route splitting; CSS animations

No preload/fetchpriority Medium

Image discovered after JS

Recommendation: next/image priority

No lab/field data Info

PSI rate-limited; no CrUX key

Recommendation: Re-run after deploy

2.6 AI Search Readiness

Score: 12/100

What Works

- GitHub profile links back with rel=me
- Rendered copy opens with name

Findings

AI crawlers 403 Critical

Verified twice

Recommendation: Vercel Firewall

Empty shell Critical

Non-JS crawlers see nothing

Recommendation: SSR

No entity statement High

No location, university, or role in copy

Recommendation: One self-contained first sentence

Thin list-style content Medium

No 130-170 word citable passages

Recommendation: Prose sections opening with direct answers

No robots.txt / llms.txt Medium

Both 404

Recommendation: robots.ts allowing AI bots; optional llms.txt

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2.7 Images

Score: 35/100

What Works

- Hero has alt text
- Rebuild uses next/image with priority on profile.jpg

Findings

9.8 MB PNG publicly served High

/IMG_0344.png 200

Recommendation: Drop from public/

No OG image High

No og:image

Recommendation: app/opengraph-image.tsx

Missing width/height Medium

<img> lacks dimensions

Recommendation: next/image

Orphan assets Low

darkshot1.jpg, Poker.jpeg

Recommendation: Remove

3. Action Plan

Phase 1: Critical Fixes Week 1

- Disable Vercel AI-bot block
- Deploy SSR rebuild with not-found.tsx and redirects for old routes
- metadataBase www + canonical + OG + twitter + proper title/description
- Ensure no multi-MB PNGs ship in public/

Phase 2: High-Impact Improvements Weeks 2-3

- JSON-LD Person/WebSite/ProfilePage
- robots.ts + sitemap.ts; GSC verification and sitemap submit
- Entity sentence + single H1
- Above-fold Resume/GitHub/LinkedIn/email links
- OG image
- Security headers

Phase 3: Content & Authority Month 2

- Project write-ups with real screenshots
- Experience + Education with dates
- Consistent name/role/location on LinkedIn, GitHub, resume; site URL on all profiles
- Mobile overflow, tap targets, text size fixes

Phase 4: Monitoring & Iteration Ongoing

- Re-run PSI/CWV after deploy
- Drift baseline
- GSC Links + Indexing review monthly
- llms.txt, PDF noindex decision

Data Sources & Methodology

Source	Description	Update Frequency
PageSpeed Insights API	Lighthouse lab audit (mobile emulation, Moto G Power, slow 4G)	Real-time
Chrome UX Report (CrUX)	28-day rolling field data from real Chrome users	Daily ~04:00 UTC
CrUX History API	25-week p75 trend data per metric	Weekly
Google Search Console	Search Analytics (clicks, impressions, CTR, position)	2-3 day lag
URL Inspection API	Per-URL index status, coverage state, crawl info	Real-time (2,000/day)

Report generated by Claude SEO — Google SEO Intelligence Skill — October 26, 2026
Methodology based on Google Web Vitals thresholds, Search Console documentation, and Lighthouse scoring algorithms.